

Sony Sound Forge 9.0a

Expert-level audio editing made easy

Sony's Sound Forge 9 is the latest version of the highly-acclaimed sound editing software. There isn't much competition left in this space, but new releases and updates still keep pouring in.

The interface hasn't changed much since the previous releases. It is still easy to use for intermediate and expert-level users.

To start with, Sound Forge allows you to import from a wide range of formats—including video formats that contain more audio streams than stereo. Let your imagination run wild with the number of effects Sound Forge gives you—flange, chorus, and reverb are just a few of them. The overwhelming number of effects and tools is what makes Sound Forge unique.

Setting up parameters for each of the effects is easy. Windows pop up for

every effect you apply where parameters can be changed, and real-time previews are played back instantaneously.

It's not all fun and games either. The Detect Clipping feature finds instances of clipping in a track and marks them so they can be treated. The Plug-In Chainer queues up multiple effects. Several audio files can be processed and effects applied one after another automatically.

Support for scripts is inbuilt, as well as some presets for normalising, cropping and fading, etc. These can be used to run automated tasks like extracting audio CDs and

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Ease of Use	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★



encoding them, for example. A script editor is provided; anyone with some understanding of programming can make his own scripts.

Sound Forge stays well under the 50 MB limit while working on more than a couple of MP3s.

As it stands now, Sony's Sound Forge has become a well-refined and optimised audio editing software that performs well and manages to have as many features as you'd want. All is well, it might seem, but the price

tag of \$299.96 (Rs 12,150) is bound to create some hesitation for prospective buyers. Professional-level users already on older Sound Forge versions will have no such doubts, all thanks to support for new formats and standards—and the added effects and tools. Newcomers to the field of audio editing would be better off starting with open source alternatives—Audacity, for example.

Web site: sonycreativesoftware.com
Price: \$299.96 (Rs 12,150)

Toon Boom Storyboard Pro

Do your story on the computer

Toon Boom Storyboard Pro should help you do away with all the paper and pens that people normally associate with storyboarding without a computer.

The interface is somewhat dull, and the layout disappoints: tools like the colour palettes are not easily accessible enough. The drawing tools are very basic; Storyboard Pro is meant for rough sketching and basic drawing, and we'd have liked better brushes. Some changes to the brush can be done to improve on the default set, though. Sounds can be added to the shots; voice-overs can be recorded in the software and added. You can also add notes—useful for dialogues.

The Onion skin feature is especially useful: it allows artists to use earlier

panels as a reference and make accurate additions to the next shots.

A few templates are provided as well. You can select from ready-made characters and items and add them to a scene by a simple drag-and-drop move.

The colour selector in Storyboard Pro is pretty advanced; it displays a wide range of colours using three separate parameters—Hue, Saturation, and Value, for the three standard colours—red, green, and blue. However, this three-wheel selection mode

RATINGS	
Performance	★★★★★
Features	★★★★★
Ease of Use	★★★★★
Value for Money	★★★★★
Overall	★★★★★

window is too large to fit into a resolution of 1152 x 864. A minimum resolution of 1280 x 1024 is required.

Storyboard Pro has incorporated cameras similar to those in 3D modelling applications. The camera can be panned and moved about. Transition effects can be set between shots—this makes Storyboard Pro a viable option as an animation tool (to some extent). Prepared animations can be exported as rendered frames in TGA and JPEG or as QuickTime or Flash animations.

Toon Boom Storyboard Pro demonstrates that by moving the process of storyboarding to a computer, it's possible to exponentially improve flexibility—make changes effortlessly; easily put



detail put into pre-production plans.

Rs 50,000 for the commercial version may seem high, but remember that professional studios' 3D software and compositing software run into lakhs. Still, you can find similar storyboarding software at around half the price. The educational package for students—which adds a watermark—is expensive, at Rs 20,000.

Contact: Rahul Commerce
Phone: 020-26113853 / 54
E-mail: rahulsales@vsnl.com
Web site: www.toonboom.com
Price: 50,000 (Commercial), Rs 20,000 (Educational with watermark)